

The Health and Safety (Display Screen Equipment) Regulations 1992

The Health and Safety (Display Screen Equipment) Regulations 1992¹ is UK legislation that aims to protect workers from the health risks associated with prolonged use of 'display screen equipment' (DSE). DSE is defined as "devices or equipment that have an alphanumeric or graphic display screen".² This includes PCs, laptops, tablets and smartphones.

The regulations apply to people who use DSE daily for continuous periods of an hour or more, rather than those who use it less frequently.³ They cover employees who have fixed workstations as well as those who are mobile workers, home workers, or 'hot-deskers' (when employees can use any available desk, rather than having a fixed workstation).

Under the regulations, employers have a number of responsibilities. Perhaps the most familiar is the requirement to carry out 'workstation assessments' for regular DSE users.⁴ This is when an assessor looks at an individual's whole workstation, including equipment, furniture, and working conditions. The assessor will also take into account the nature of the job being carried out and whether the employee has any particular requirements, for example, if they have a disability.

This assessment should identify any potential hazards – for instance, poor posture or inadequate lighting – and then recommend ways to minimise the risks. These might involve adjusting the height of the chair or display screen, providing a footrest or ensuring adequate lighting and ventilation.

Workstation assessments should take place when a new employee starts work, when a workstation changes, or when employees complain of difficulties.

As well as workstation assessments, the DSE regulations say that employers must give employees regular breaks from screen work, recommending short breaks often, rather than longer ones less often.⁵ This might involve switching to tasks that don't involve a display screen or giving people breaks to move around, stretch and rest their eyes.

Resting eyes is related to another employer responsibility under the regulations. If a DSE user requests an eye test, their employer must fund a full vision and eye examination. Employers also have to pay for glasses if the employee needs them for the specific distance at which they view their screen.⁶

¹ Legislation.gov.uk (N.D.). The Health and Safety (Display Screen Equipment) Regulations 1992. Available at: <https://www.legislation.gov.uk/uksi/1992/2792/contents/made> [Accessed 8 May 2025]

² Health and Safety Executive (N.D.). Working with display screen equipment (DSE): A brief guide. Available at: <https://www.hse.gov.uk/pubns/indg36.PDF> [Accessed 8 May 2025]

³ Health and Safety Executive (N.D.). Working safely with display screen equipment. Available at: <https://www.hse.gov.uk/msd/dse/index.htm#article> [Accessed 8 May 2025]

⁴ Health and Safety Executive (N.D.). Working safely with display screen equipment. Workstations and assessment. Available at: <https://www.hse.gov.uk/msd/dse/assessment.htm> [Accessed 8 May 2025]

⁵ Health and Safety Executive (N.D.). Working safely with display screen equipment. Work routine and breaks. Available at: <https://www.hse.gov.uk/msd/dse/work-routine.htm> [Accessed 8 May 2025]

⁶ Health and Safety Executive (N.D.). Working safely with display screen equipment. Eyes and eyesight testing. Available at: <https://www.hse.gov.uk/msd/dse/eye-tests.htm> [Accessed 8 May 2025]

Employers are also responsible for giving employees training and information around DSE. This should include guidance on how they can arrange their desks, adjust their chairs and screens, maintain good posture, take regular breaks, conduct risk assessments and report any problems.⁷

For people in office-based roles, the use of display screen equipment is usually an essential aspect of the job because they tend to spend significant amounts of time working on computers and other electronic devices – including long periods spent sitting and typing. Because of this, they may be particularly vulnerable to the risks associated with the improper use of display screen equipment. These might include back and neck pain, as well as upper-limb problems that affect the shoulders, arms, wrists, hands, and fingers.⁸

Employees who work with DSE for prolonged periods should therefore ensure that their workstation is set up in a way that means they're working in a comfortable position, with good posture. This may also help to reduce the risk of eye problems. In addition, appropriate lighting and adjusting the position of computer monitors can reduce glare and improve visibility. Meanwhile, taking 'screen breaks' and performing eye exercises might help to relieve eyesight-related problems like tired or sore eyes, eye strain and headaches.

Indeed, a correctly set up workstation, good posture and regular breaks can help to avoid fatigue or discomfort. This reduces the chances of suffering from a related health condition, which in turn makes people more effective and productive in their roles.

⁷ Health and Safety Executive (N.D.). Working safely with display screen equipment. Training and information. Available at: <https://www.hse.gov.uk/msd/dse/training-information.htm> [Accessed 8 May 2025]

⁸ Health and Safety Executive (N.D.). Working with display screen equipment (DSE): A brief guide. Available at: <https://www.hse.gov.uk/pubns/indg36.PDF> [Accessed 8 May 2025]